

CORE FORMULA

Echo their key phrase + one small question + pause. -> Weirdly political - how so? -> Hidden rules layer - what do you mean by that? -> Not sustainable - what part feels unsustainable? -> A good kind of intense - what made it good? -> Dismissed - what made it land that way?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Repeat the key word or phrase, then ask one short question: "how?", "what part?", or "what do you mean by that?"

BEST FOR

- Keeping a conversation moving without asking a generic question
- Helping someone expand a specific phrase, value, concern or story detail
- Clarifying vague but meaningful words such as "weird", "messy", "political", "draining" or "interesting"
- Networking, dating, social conversation, coaching and workplace chats
- Conflict or objection handling, when one word reveals the real concern
- Understanding before persuading, advising, requesting or disagreeing
- Making follow-up questions sound natural rather than interview-like

PHRASE BANK

Quick defaults · Short follow-ups to append after the echoed word

- "How so?"
- "In what way?"
- "What part, exactly?"
- "What do you mean by that?"
- "What happened there?"
- "Say more about that word?"

Warm and natural · Warm, low-pressure echoes

- "That word sounds important. What made it feel that way?"
- "You said 'draining'. What part was draining?"
- "That sounds like the real bit. What happened there?"
- "You used the word 'stuck'. Stuck how?"
- "That sounds more complicated than the short version."
- "'A lot' sounds loaded. A lot how?"

Charismatic / social · Playful two-option echoes

- "Chaotic in a fun way or a why-am-I-here way?"
- "Unexpectedly good? That needs the story."
- "Weirdly satisfying - weirdly how?"
- "That phrase is doing a lot of work. Explain."
- "Good-intense or bad-intense?"

Professional / workplace · Clarifying vague business words

- "When you say 'risk', what risk specifically?"
- "By 'not sustainable', what are you seeing?"
- "What does 'done properly' mean here?"
- "You mentioned 'alignment'. Alignment around what?"

- "When you say 'priority', what should we optimise for?"
- "'Blocked' - blocked by what?"

High-status / senior person · Precise, time-respecting asks

- "When you say 'priority', what specifically should we optimise for?"
- "By 'concise', do you mean one page or just the decision points?"
- "When you say 'too slow', where is the bottleneck?"
- "What does 'good enough' look like here?"
- "What is the key constraint?"

Conflict / resistance · Echo the charged word after validating

- "You said 'unfair'. What would have felt fair?"
- "Dismissed - what made it land that way?"
- "Stuck - is that about the decision or how it was handled?"
- "Rushed - what part felt rushed?"
- "Not heard - what do you need me to understand first?"

Digital / text · Shortest possible echoes for messaging

- "Messy how?"
- "Complicated in what way?"
- "Good-intense or bad-intense?"
- "What's the 'political' bit?"
- "What part is the real issue?"

Shy or guarded person · Permission and softness before the echo

- "No need to go into it, but when you say 'odd', what kind of odd?"
- "If you are comfortable saying, what made it feel off?"
- "You mentioned it was a bit much. Was that the people side or the task side?"
- "We can leave it there, but 'weird' sounds like the key word."
- "Was it more awkward or more stressful?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Tell me more."
Better: "What was that like?"
Best: "You said it was weirdly intense - weirdly intense how?"
- Weak: "Why?"
Better: "Why did that matter?"
Best: "That word sounds important. What made it matter?"
- Weak: Repeating the whole sentence back
Better: Repeating just the key word
Best: Echoing the useful phrase and adding one small question
- Weak: "What exactly do you mean by that?" in a sharp tone
Better: "What do you mean by that?"
Best: "Hidden rules layer - what do you mean by that?"
- Weak: Using their words to challenge them
Better: Using their word to clarify
Best: "When you say unfair, what would have felt fair from your side?"

DECISION TREE

If They expand on the thread

Reflect the key meaning, then ask one deeper or more practical follow-up.
"So the hard part is the map, not the work?"

If They correct your interpretation

Accept it cleanly and carry on with their version.

"Got it - that is a better way to put it."

If They seem embarrassed by the word

Soften and lower the stakes.

"No pressure, I just noticed the word."

If They give a brief, flat answer

Comment more and ask less; do not keep drilling.

"Fair enough - it just sounded like the interesting bit."

If They become defensive

Move to validation and take the weight off the word.

"I might have read too much into that."

If They turn the question back on you

Answer briefly, then return if their thread still has energy.

"For me it was similar - but I want to hear the rest of yours."

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

Break generic small talk by echoing the odd or loaded word. — "Oddly satisfying - oddly how?"

Professional discussion

Clarify a vague business word before you act on it. — "When you say risk, what risk specifically?"

Conflict or objection

Echo the charged word, but only after you have validated the feeling. — "Dismissed - what made it land that way?"

Digital message

Use the shortest possible echo so it reads as interest, not effort. — "Messy how?"

High-status or busy person

Keep the wording precise and time-respecting. — "By priority, what should we optimise for?"

Shy or guarded person

Offer permission and softness before the echo. — "No need to go into it, but when you say odd, what kind of odd?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They are emotionally overwhelmed and need validation before any more questioning
- Their wording is private, embarrassing or vulnerable and echoing it could feel exposing
- You have already echoed several phrases in a row
- You are tempted to use their words to trap, corner or cross-examine them
- They need a clear answer, decision or practical help, not more exploration
- The setting is public and the echo would put them on the spot
- They are giving short answers and the move starts to feel like effort extraction

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the word

In three conversations, just notice the one distinctive or loaded word in what each person says. Do not act on it yet - only train your ear to find the live phrase.

Day 2 — Echo only

Repeat the key word or short phrase back lightly and warmly, with no question attached. Watch what happens when you simply hand their own word back.

Day 3 — Echo plus one question

Now add one short question after the echo ("how?", "what part?"), then stop talking and let them expand. Resist the urge to answer your own question.

Day 4 — Reflect after

Once they answer, reflect the meaning back in a single sentence so they feel understood, not just interviewed.

Day 5 — Contribute after

After one or two follow-ups, add a small thought or brief story of your own so the exchange stays a conversation, not an interrogation.

Day 6 — Hard mode

Use the move once in a mildly tense or resistant moment - but only after validating the feeling first. Echo the charged word, ask gently, then listen.

Day 7 — Review and prune

Note which echoes felt natural versus forensic. Cut any wording that sounded like analysing rather than listening, and keep the versions that felt easy.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I echo a word that actually mattered to them, not just any word?
- Did I echo lightly and warmly, rather than theatrically or forensically?
- Was my question short and easy to answer?
- Did I avoid using their words to trap or challenge them?
- Did I stop before it tipped into parroting or an interview?
- Did I contribute something of my own after one or two follow-ups?